John Dalvi had had their hands tied, but once the action started, both commanders failed their men completely. At Bridge 1 and Bridge 2, the largest number of troops was available—almost two battalions, nearly half of 7 Brigade. Both these positions were naturally protected from a frontal assault owing to the steepness of the Thagla slopes, and the troops were at a much lower altitude. A basic assessment of any anticipated attack would have made it obvious that to get to these two units, the Chinese would have to break through the 2 Rajput positions which, despite their poor tactical setting, would put up a fight. Yet, between the division, brigade and the two commanding officers, they sat back and allowed the Chinese to systematically destroy individual platoons piecemeal.

On the Nam Ka Chu, the Chinese easily broke up the front into three parts. The first section, to the extreme west (Bridge 5) was ignored; then according to their strategy, they broke up the remaining area into two halves, allowing them to bring down all their strength on the left portion, including Tsangdhar.

From analysing reports of events on the ground, it's clear to me that the fighting withdrawal of 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers recorded in the official history could not have taken place as neither battalion was in hostile contact with the Chinese, who had deliberately left them alone through the entire day. A few mortar rounds had landed on the 9 Punjab position around 8.30 a.m. but that had fizzled out after a while. Both the commanding officers, in the absence of any direction or communication from either Dalvi or Prasad, simply did not know what to do. After a while, the fighting in the Rajput and Gorkha positions had all but died down, with only the dead and dying lying amongst the rocks and destroyed bunkers.

At 9 a.m., Lieutenant Colonel Mishra had sent a patrol along with his Signals lineman towards Rongla to check on the status of the telephone line. The patrol reported that Rongla had most probably been abandoned as Chinese troops were swarming over the entire area. At Bridge 1, the Grenadiers were also completely cut off, though they could hear the din of the battles being fought by 2 Rajput to their west and their own Charlie Company to the north as they fiercely defended the Drokung Samba Bridge. Firing from this direction had also died down except for the odd burst of gunfire every now and then. At midday, Major Oscar Thomas, the adjutant, finally got through to Zimithang by plugging into the brigade-division line, even though the brigade end was ominously silent. Division HQ conveyed